



eBox 0.9.1

Site: www.ebox-platform.com

Size: 205 MB

eBox is a really unique distribution with a lot of potential, not just for home users, but even small offices, and can scale to much larger networks. It acts like a router with a dozen additional features like proxy, firewall, routing, VPN, and many others thrown in—things a router normally can't do. It's a full-fledged, remotely controllable network server. eBox is a 200 MB distribution that boots off the CD without any trouble.



Your all-in-one network server!

There is no user interface—no taskbars, no menus, nothing! It directly loads an elegant page on Firefox which is, in fact, the Web interface from where you control all the features of this operating system. This means you can remotely access the server over the network too.

There is a lot this distribution can do: you can add multiple network interfaces and gateways. You can then set it to load-balance requests to the gateways. Traffic shaping allows you set bandwidth limitations. The HTTP proxy can be configured to block files of certain extensions, MIME types, or entire sites altogether. Easy switching of strictness for the proxy can be done by changing a single setting called Content Filter Threshold.

The firewall in eBox can be set up to block ports and also for port forwarding. eBox can also route data from one network to another.

The VPN capabilities here are very interesting indeed. OpenVPN is a free, open source application that comes with eBox; it allows multiple users from all over the network or the Internet to connect and form a virtual network. There is no limit to the number of connections.

Communications And Networking

What do you do with an old PC that you can't sell? Linux is a perfect operating system for network servers. Here are some distributions that take your scrap-worthy machine and turn it into a network server or a telephony box.

There is an option to back up settings to a drive, but we found no option to install the OS. The eBox site has a separate installer image for download for that purpose.

You should be able to run eBox on pretty much any machine. The highlight here is that it's easy for non-technical people to use, thanks to the Web interface.

AsteriskNOW Beta 6

Site: www.asterisknow.org

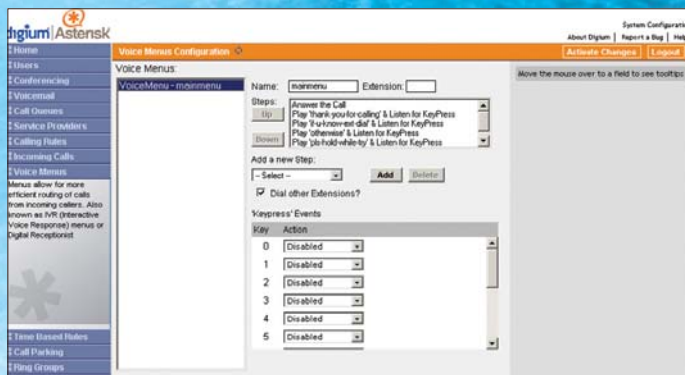
Size: 447 MB

AsteriskNOW is a Linux distribution that turns your computer into a mini PBX (Private Branch Exchange)—a mini phone exchange—for both telephone and VoIP calls. It is not a Live CD, so you'll need to install it to disk. Upon boot-up, you'll see just a text-based interface, and there's nothing that can be done here.

To get to the most functional part of the OS, you need to connect to the AsteriskNOW machine through a browser from anywhere on the network. The setup Wizard helps you set up the system the first time you log in, and the Web interface is well-laid-out.

You can set up multiple phone providers and then assign them to different users—not only can you use your regular analogue phone line, you can add online VoIP providers as well.

Connections can be set up in a manner such that numbers starting with certain codes can be routed through different providers, and calls coming from a particular provider can be automatically sent to particular extensions. It also supports conferencing in addition to the standard three-way phone calls. In addition, there are voice menus to interact with callers, and you can assign functions to a number of keystrokes.



This can be your personal telephone exchange